The Theravada Buddhist tradition

As we have seen, Buddhism has played a complex role in Burmese history. The Pagan Kingdom and its successors in one sense effectively fused state and religion and acted as sponsors for the Theravada strand of Buddhism, but equally they seem to have been broadly tolerant of ethnic minorities and non-Buddhist religious groups. One critique of British rule was that its indifference to safeguarding the Buddhist hierarchy was the mark of an illegitimate regime. The leadership of the Buddhist monks today looks back to the relationship they had with the kings before British rule. In effect, Buddhism in Myanmar has a long history of relying on the state in a two-way relationship. The kings provided the state power needed to enforce Buddhism and the Buddhists provided legitimacy, as 'the ultimate wielders of violence, for the support, patronage and order that only they could provide. Kings looked to monks to provide the popular legitimacy that only such a high moral vision can confer'.[51]

The Theravada strand in Buddhism is common across Sri Lanka, Myanmar and Thailand.[52] Equally, in all three countries there are ample examples of the local Buddhist leadership acting with complete intolerance towards other religious minorities, and one reason for this is the interpretation of Buddhism common to this strand. It is not that Theravada Buddhism is always about extreme nationalism and intolerance towards other beliefs, but that there are elements within its belief system that make it very vulnerable to being captured by those who wish to construct an exclusive, confessionally pure, polity.

In this context, the key tradition in the Theravada *sasana* (teaching) is that which links religion to state power. As we saw in the previous chapter, the Pagan rulers, in search of legitimacy, deliberately provided this protection and allowed Buddhism to spread. Any state tolerance of non-Buddhist religions is thought to threaten the existence of both state and religion. Theravada Buddhists cite approvingly the actions of a Buddhist king in Sri Lanka who defeated a Tamil invasion. Since he fought a defensive war to protect the *sasana*, he was absolved of any responsibility for the loss of life. Indeed, he was assured that only one-and-a-half 'people' had actually died: these were an enemy soldier who had fully converted to Buddhism and one who had taken partial vows.[53] The rest of the dead were